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India's Soft Power Diplomacy in the Indo-Pacific: A Special Reference to Seychelles

Amit K. Singh, Aparna*

Department of International Relations, Central University of Jharkhand, Cheri-Manatu, Ranchi, India

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Corresponding Author:
Aparna
Email: aparna@cuj.ac.in

Abstract

The Indo-Pacific region is being subjected to continuous changes in this 21st century concerning soft power policies that are extremely important from strategic and economic viewpoints. Since 2016, two particular issues cantering the Indo-Pacific region have attracted worldwide attention. First, the importance of the involvement of the Indo-Pacific region in international politics, economics and security discussions on the grounds of The Rim Association. Second, India's emerging role as a soft power in the Indo-Pacific region with reference to its evolving relation with Seychelles. It must be noted here that Seychelles is continuously flourishing in terms of its overall development in the Indo-Pacific region. According to Joseph Nye, soft power is "the ability to get what you want through attraction rather than coercion or payments. It arises from the attractiveness of a country's culture, political ideals, and policies." India is continuously strengthening its relations with Seychelles, primarily by engaging itself in soft power politics; by protecting as well as strategically strengthening Seychelles in the Indo-Pacific region on the grounds of security. Cultural policies, historical ties, foreign policies, completion of several projects, meetings between heads of state, military exercises and purchase of security equipment- all these have essentially impacted establishing a strong relationship between India and Seychelles. In the near future, this might pave the path to India to further strengthen the capability of its soft power in the Indo-Pacific region and stand up against China in a more diplomatic way. How India is strengthening its relationship with Seychelles via soft power diplomacy and how much successful power India has been in the Indo-Pacific region in terms of its foreign policies with respect to its political and economic strategies are the major topics of discussion throughout this paper.

INTRODUCTION

As a defining geopolitical framework, the "Indo-Pacific" emerged in 2017 to link the destinies of governments from East Africa to East Asia with those of key powers, including the United States, China, India, and Japan. Beijing has garnered attention for its efforts to control the eastern portion of this integrated system in the South China Sea, but it has avoided the geographical limitations of the western Indian Ocean by establishing influence and infrastructure that may one day result in political, ethical, and ideological control over Asia's littorals. China and the liberal order, which has been headed by the US but is increasingly being represented by India, are engaged in a struggle for the Indo-soul of the Pacific in the western Indian Ocean. Although a tentative rapprochement between New Delhi and Beijing has started, their interests do not align. Despite the recent friendship between Chinese President Xi Jinping and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Wuhan, it is clear that China's "non-market" economic policies and military actions are starting to shrink India's strategic space in the western Indian Ocean. Seychelles has failed to ratify an agreement with India on the construction of a military facility at Assumption Island, just weeks after Indian Foreign Secretary Subramanian Jaishankar signed a revised agreement for its development, which included the construction of an airstrip and a jetty for the Seychelles Coast Guard and Indian Navy. Sri Lanka is enslaved in an odd relationship with the Middle Kingdom. In spite of having less resources and a smaller economy than China, Delhi is shown a willingness to respond. President Ram Nath Kovind's recent trip to Mauritius and Madagascar may have demonstrated India's reaction to China's threat in the East African and West Asian littorals. Governments all around the globe are developing new methods to increase their influence in the Indo-Pacific area as its strategic significance rises. Although multilateral alliances in the Indo-Pacific have a long history, many contemporary initiatives are in reaction to China's expansion in the area's economy, politics, and military.

Soft Power Diplomacy

Since the term "soft power" was first used by American political scientist Joseph S. Nye Jr. in the 1980s, governments all over the world have adopted it as a strategy for increasing their stature and influence on a global scale. Instead of referring to a country's military might, "soft power" describes its ability to entice other nations with its culture, foreign policy, and political ideologies. This information has served as the cornerstone for governments' public diplomacy initiatives and cross-cultural engagement with state and non-state actors. Even though the notion of "soft power" is only a few decades old, several nations are well-known on a global scale for their centuries-old cultural treasures and principles that are still in demand today. One such nation

is India, whose civilizational background and cultural prowess form the foundation of its soft power. Contrary to many other countries that have homogenised, or rather "westernised," their traditions, India's diverse but cohesive cultural fabric covers the length and breadth of the nation. Additionally, expressions of Indian soft power include the rise in the country's stature in recent decades at various multilateral forums, the popularity of Yoga and Ayurveda, and the widespread adoption of the salutation Namaste in the midst of the current pandemic. India's millennia-old traditions and expertise, which are still relevant today, represent the soft power of its civilization. In addition to being exceedingly scientific, the Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS) are also immensely aesthetic and linguistic. IKS's breadth has been echoed in both physical and intangible spheres of existence, from science to cuisine to architecture. The Nataraja (dancing Shiva) sculpture on the premises of the European Organization for Nuclear Research (CERN) in Switzerland exemplifies the IKS thesis that there is a universal connection between humanity and the cosmos. Buddhism and Indian epics like the Ramayana and Mahabharata were transmitted around the globe and are still alive and well today, especially in Southeast Asia. Localized versions of the Ramayana, such as Ramekin in Thailand and Kakawin in Indonesia, have been adapted to theatre, dance, and other crafts in these countries, greatly enhancing their creative and cultural economies.

India is a soft power based on culture. One example is the accessibility and enjoyment of Indian film as a form of entertainment in violently unstable Afghanistan. Indian cuisine is another important cultural export, whether it be the café-sold turmeric latte, the gourmet dishes made with jackfruit, or Australian Prime Minister Scott Morison's diplomatic usage of samosas. Other important facets of Indian soft power include literature, performing arts, fashion and handicrafts, tourism, and the arts. It is crucial to create a strong cultural creative economy that provides creative entrepreneurs with increasing chances to spread Indian culture worldwide to realise and maximize the potential of such traditions and practices. This may also result in cross-cultural collaboration and learning opportunities for global cultural specialists, businesspeople, and hobbyists.

India in Indo-Pacific: Soft Power Diplomacy

The phrase "Indo-Pacific" has lately gained popularity and almost supplanted the previous term "Asia-Pacific," notably in the United States, India, Japan, and Australia. This shift in vocabulary has often been seen in Russia through the lens of the U.S.-China conflict and Washington's ambition to bolster its influence in that region of the globe by enlisting India on its side. However, India is creating its own conceptual frameworks based on New Delhi's worldview and national objectives, even if they may use the same name.

When the phrase "Asia-Pacific" was initially used, South Asia was not included. India is not a full member of the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC), which hosted high-profile yearly meetings from the 1990s through the 2010s. As for India, it started developing new geopolitical theories in the wake of the Cold War that took into account the drastically altered global landscape. The "Look East" policy of the P. V. Narasimha Rao administration in 1991 signaled a significant change in India's global view after the Cold War and marked the beginning of the diplomatic and economic component of New Delhi's strategy. It was also seen as a crucial element in India's desire to open up its economy and benefit from the vibrant East Asia area. India's severe issues with Pakistan to the west and China to the north, which restrict its overland contacts and commerce with both countries, have had an impact on its strategic thinking. India, therefore, turned its gaze both eastward and toward the Indian Ocean. India's severe issues with Pakistan to the west and China to the north, which restrict its overland contacts and commerce with both countries, have had an impact on its strategic thinking. The foundations of India's present Indo-Pacific strategy were established at the beginning of the twenty-first century. Following the 1998 Indian nuclear tests, the United States started a strategy of reconciliation with India, which boosted Indo-U.S. relations. Following the horrific tsunami of December 26, 2004, which claimed around 225,000 lives in Indonesia, Sri Lanka, Thailand, and India, the next phase of Indo-U.S. relations began. The United States, Australia, India, and Japan created a coalition to provide emergency aid to people impacted at the request of then-U.S. President George W. Bush. The coalition only lasted a week, but it inspired the idea of a quadrilateral alliance, or the Quad. Shinzo Abe, the prime minister of Japan, attempted to formally establish the organisation in 2006, but it failed. Since then, many nations have made several policy changes in response to China's rapid ascent and rising aggressiveness, which are demonstrated by events in the East and South China Seas and the region's overall increase in prominence. Washington and Tokyo started collaborating with New Delhi to include it in the strategic equation in order to counterbalance China's rising power and spreading influence. They changed their strategic ideas around the idea of the "Indo-Pacific" to do it. East of the Malacca Straits, India is not a big economic or military power. However, its geographic location to the west of the straits serves as a significant anchor for any plan connecting the Pacific and the Indian Ocean. Out of the 10 ASEAN nations, India has marine and land borders with four of them. India, which protrudes 2,000 kilometres into the Indian Ocean, also controls the western end of the Malacca Straits and is situated along important shipping channels.

Challenges faced by India

India is continuously facing numerous challenges. Some such are:

- Limited Naval Capacity.
- Lack of military bases.
- Challenges to trade: Tariff and non-tariff measures (NTMs) and poor infrastructure connectivity.
- Slow pace of developments of initiatives.
- Balancing Continental and Maritime Strategies.
- Challenges to MDA: submarine deployments, grey shipping and dark shipping.
- Disapproval from within due to divergence from traditional positions on nonalignment.
- Barriers to fruitful partnerships: Lack of definitional consensus and differences in priorities.

Seychelles Island in Indo-Pacific: Soft Power Diplomacy

The archipelagic microstate of Seychelles is located in the Indian Ocean, close to the equator, some 1,600 km east of the Kenyan coast. The nation is significantly spread among 115 islands, some of which are 1,000 km (the Farquhar and Aldabra groups) southwest of Mahe, the main island where Victoria, the capital city, is located. This is despite the fact that the country has a comparatively small land mass. As a result, the Seychelles' 1.4 million square kilometer Economic Exclusive Zone (EEZ) is huge and challenging to administer. With a GDP per capital of approximately $17,000, Seychelles—known for its upscale tourist industry—might surpass Mauritius as the richest country

in Africa. Since it is no longer regarded as a high-income country by the World Bank as of 2015, it is no longer eligible for development funds from OECD countries. The Seychelles, which have been independently run since 1976, supported the Soviet Union up to the end of the Cold War while also retaining diplomatic ties with the US, which was still allowed to keep a satellite surveillance station on Mahé, the main island. In addition, positive relationships were built with China, India, and the country's former colonizer, the United Kingdom. 7 After the nation transitioned to multiparty democracy in 1991, the first democratic elections were conducted in 1993. Since then, the Seychelles have mostly progressed toward Westernization as a result of the promotion of tourism. Germany, France, and Italy account for the bulk of visitors to the Seychelles, but so do a rising number of travelers from Asia, the Middle East, and Russia. Since 1977, just one political party has controlled Seychelles' political landscape: the socialism-leaning Seychelles People's United Party, which France-Albert René formed in 1964. (SPUP). René, who presided over the country from 1977 to 2004, was the sole recognized party till 1991. The SPUP changed its name many times (United Seychelles since 2018), but it was able to maintain power as the country's ruling party until 2016. René was succeeded in office by one of his close allies, former vice president James Michel, until his party, the people's party (or Parti Lepep in Créole, one of the three official languages along with English and French), lost the parliamentary election in October 2016 to a coalition of opposition parties, the Linyon Democratic Seselwa (LDS or Seychelles Democratic Union), led by opposition chief Wavel Ramkalawan. Until then, Michel stayed in control (14 against 19 seats in the 33 seat Parliament). Vice President Danny Faure, who had previously held a variety of ministerial roles, including the Finance Ministry, assumed over when Michel resigned. Ramkalawan, the leader of the Seychelles National Party (SNP), the LDS's largest component, narrowly lost to Michel in the 2015 presidential election, which had contested results. He subsequently beat Faure in October 2020, taking office in the midst of economic troubles caused on by the sharp fall in tourism brought on by COVID-19. Compared to before, the LDS has a significantly stronger presence in the National Assembly (25 against 10 for United Seychelles in a 35 seat Parliament). Although it is more nationalist, the latter is probably more liberal and committed to democracy and human rights. In the first, social democracy is claimed. Their positions on a variety of issues are similar, with the main distinction being that the LDS represents the views of individuals who disapproved of René's rule, which included land expropriation and disappearances. Seychelles' foreign policy is categorically non-aligned. However, it still has friendly connections with some of its old allies, including as Russia and Cuba, both of which retain embassies in Victoria. Since democracy, it has also grown closer to the West and new emerging powers and neighbors. The Indian Ocean Commission (IOC), the Common Market for Eastern and Southern Africa (COMESA), the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation (IOR-ARC), and the Alliance of Small Island States are among the regional organizations in which Seychelles now actively participates (OASIS). It emphasizes developing its blue economy. It is keen to preserve friendly ties with all of its "major bilateral friends," including China, while defending global norms, including the Law of the Sea and human rights. It often votes at the United Nations in agreement with the European Union and other like-minded countries (for example on Syria). 8 Like other micro-states, Seychelles only has eleven diplomatic missions, among them the Sovereign Military Order of Malta (an international body which is not a country). Only the UK (really a High Commission) and France have embassies in Seychelles; the UK due to Seychelles' historical ties and Commonwealth membership; and France due to its extensive holdings and interests in the Indian Ocean. The other countries holding diplomatic representation in Victoria are China (since 1977), India (since 2008, despite the fact that it started relations in 1979 and has maintained a permanent post since 1987), the United Arab Emirates (since 2011), Sri Lanka (since 2014), and Japan (2018). Although the US ambassador is also accredited to the Seychelles, which he visits every two months, and is based in Mauritius, the US government is seriously contemplating reopening an embassy in Victoria. This was probably influenced by Japan's previous actions. However, the Seychelles are dominated by geostrategic confrontation between China and India. Behind these two emerging superpowers, between Washington and Beijing.

Cooperation between Seychelles and India in Indo-Pacific: An Analysis

At a formal virtual inauguration ceremony on April 8, 2021, Seychelles accepted the quick patrol ship PS Zoroaster, funded by the Government of India. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, President of the Seychelles Wavel Ramkalawan, and other senior diplomats and government representatives attended the ceremony. There were also celebrations for the completion of the Magistrates Court, which was funded by a GoI grant of US $3.4 million, and the building of a 1-megawatt solar facility on Romainville Island, which will provide enough energy to power around 400 people. The inauguration commemorated the completion of ten similar projects on the Seychelles' three largest islands, Mahe, Praslin, and La Digue. The engagement of India with its smaller island neighbors now heavily relies on "High Impact Community Development Projects."

Despite PS Zoroaster being India's fourth patrol ship to be delivered to Seychelles (the first, PS Topaz, was provided in 2005), its unveiling highlighted how India's attitude toward its little island neighbors nearby is progressively changing. It has particularly highlighted the strengthening and growing importance of India's relations with the Seychelles, an archipelago of 115 islands with a population of 98,000. When Modi visited Sri Lanka, Seychelles, and Mauritius as part of his Indian Ocean Tour in 2015, it was clear that the bilateral relationship between India and this African archipelago country now included a new and important maritime security component. He critically started the Coastal Surveillance Radar Project in the Seychelles on this trip. This was further shown by External Affairs Minister Subrahmanyam Jaishankar's urgent November visit to Victoria after President Ramkalawan's electoral victory in October of the same year.

Assumption Island Project

Assumption Island is located about 1,100 miles southwest of Mahé, the Seychelle's largest island. As part of the development, a coast guard facility was envisioned to assist in monitoring for criminal activity such as piracy, illegal fishing, and drug trafficking. The project faced essentially two types of opposition. One set of legitimate environmental concerns was Assumption's proximity to Aldabra, a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The other concerns that needed to be addressed were the sovereignty of the island and the fear that this might wind up being a military base used by India rather than a coast guard post. Despite efforts by the GoI to subsequently clarify that it was 'a joint project' that India was merely 'executing at the request of the Government of Seychelles,'. The opposition to the project led by Ramkalawan

received substantial public support, and eventually the project became so mired in the sovereignty debate that no government was likely to find it politically viable. Ramkalawan also said emphatically in a post-election interview, "It is completely evident our sovereignty is priceless, and there will never be a foreign military base in the Seychelles under my watch. Ramkalawan's resistance to the notion has been outspoken and intensified since 2015. He said, "I don't believe China or India would be interested in setting up a base in the Seychelles.

Beyond Assumption Island

Given the negative perceptions of the transaction and the fact that President Ramkalawan was its most vociferous opponent, it is unlikely that it will be reconsidered anytime soon. Ramkalawan, who took power in the middle of a pandemic, would instead focus on solving the current issue. Several countries are courting Seychelles because of its strategic location, including China, France, the United Arab Emirates, and even Russia, which just gave US $500,000 to the COVID-19 rescue fund. Other interested countries include China, France, and the United Arab Emirates. India is aiming to proactively change its position toward its smaller neighbours by emphasising human development via its High Impact Community Development Projects rather than competing with them. For the time being, it seems that India has made the decision to abandon the Assumption Island project and focus its efforts on other cooperative ventures, such as city twinning, hydrography, and civil infrastructure. In addition to concentrating on what the Seychelles need from its friends, India should continue to emphasise the significance of the Seychelles for its security goals. Despite the minimal number of COVID-19 cases in Seychelles, the pandemic has significantly impacted travel restrictions and a general decline in international travel. Seychelles goals of reaching out to partners, promoting tourism, reopening the nation to trade, and economic development are inextricably linked. Sylvester Radegonde's dual role as minister of tourism and foreign affairs serves as another evidence of how crucial tourism is to the Seychelles economy. President Ramkalawan acknowledged this in a statement: 'If we are close to meeting our aim of obtaining 70% of herd immunity by end of April 2021 and have reopened our country to commerce, it is, in large part, because to this valuable gesture.' The conversations Jaishankar had with Radegonde on business, travel, and trade were also favorably welcomed in this respect.

It is imperative for India to challenge the pervasive and established perception in its area that India is solely interested in its smaller neighbors for its own strategic goals, given that the Assumption Island Project's opponents were able to win over a sizeable percentage of the general population. Development programs that address the pressing needs of the general populace will have some impact on public perceptions of India.

CONCLUSION

Seychelles has used its strategic position, geopolitical significance, and the interest that all of the other nations in the IOR have exhibited in it to its advantage in the discussions with those states. In order to indirectly counteract China's rising interest in its strategic position and blue resources, it may depend on its main security allies, namely India, the US, and France. In other words, one should not underestimate Seychelles' agency or, more broadly, the power of tiny island nations to shape outcomes, particularly outcomes that affect their own security and future, in this debate of India-China rivalry in Seychelles. India has expanded its military capability to operate across the IOR, from the seas off the shores of Africa to the Malacca Strait, in an effort to enhance its position there. India would strive to further expand its footprint in the IOR as the international order is projected to undergo a geostrategic change in the aftermath of the COVID-19 epidemic. India would eagerly expand its gambit with Indian Ocean littoral nations like Sri Lanka, the Maldives, Mauritius, and Seychelles in this dynamic to examine China's growth. Without outright labeling such actions as "anti-Chinese initiatives," India is also likely to adopt a strategic strategy with the US. More than 75% of worldwide marine commerce and 50% of daily global oil transfers transit across the Indian Ocean, making it one of the planet's most important strategic sites. India's major goal will be to preserve a stable and peaceful Indian Ocean, with an emphasis on making changes to its economy and military that will eliminate the dangerous Chinese menace. The Indo-Pacific framework has allowed India to achieve its strategic goals while adapting to changes in the security environment. Despite the political fervor of New Delhi and its allies, the road map and pace of execution for realizing the Indo-Pacific vision are still restrained. The key players must acknowledge and accept that their visions for the Indo-Pacific will never be completely congruent as they go ahead. New Delhi and its partners must continue to emphasize the bigger and underlying ideas of democracy, the rule of law, and other shared interests in the Indo-Pacific while concentrating on issue-based alliances. New Delhi should seek out new connections based on shared interests. India should now focus on other unconventional players with comparable objectives as interactions have been few.

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